

PEOPLE POLICY TEMPLATE • UK & IRELAND

Grievance Procedure for UK and Ireland

A fair, timely and practical framework for raising, reviewing and resolving workplace concerns.

HOW TO USE THIS TEMPLATE

A policy to adapt with care

This template is designed for organisations operating in the United Kingdom and Ireland. Replace all placeholders, including **(company)**, **(People/HR contact)**, and internal policy links, before publication.

> **Important:** This is a reusable operational template, not legal advice. Have it reviewed against applicable UK and Irish law, collective agreements, local practice, data-protection requirements and your organisation's own policies before implementation.

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Owner

(People/HR function)
Policy owner: _____
Approved by: _____

Review details

Effective date: _____
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POLICY FRAMEWORK

Introduction, scope & definitions

PURPOSE

The purpose of this grievance procedure is to enable employees who have a concern or complaint arising from their employment with **(company)** to have it dealt with fairly and in a timely manner.

This procedure applies to all board members and employees of **(company) UK and Ireland**. **(company)** may depart from the precise requirements of this procedure where it is expedient and where the resulting treatment of the employee is no less fair.

SCOPE

This procedure applies to all **(company)** business functions and departments in the UK and Ireland, and to activities occurring both in and outside the workplace where employees are undertaking their duties or are otherwise in a work-connected context. Examples include event venues, customer or vendor sites, business travel, digital collaboration channels, and any other activity sufficiently linked to **(company)**, during or outside normal business hours.

> Concerns should be raised promptly and addressed under this procedure where appropriate. Complaints dating back 12 months or more may be treated as out of scope where they were not previously raised, are unrelated to current issues, or where **(company)** determines this is appropriate. Commission-related concerns should be raised under the relevant commission policy.

DEFINITION

Grievance: a concern or complaint raised by an employee in relation to their work environment, terms and conditions of employment, or work relationships.

INITIAL REVIEW

Pre-screening of grievances

On receipt of a grievance, **(People/HR team)** will undertake an initial review of the complaint and any evidence provided.

1. **Receive & acknowledge**
   The grievance is received through the organisation's designated written submission channel. The employee is informed of the next steps and any information needed.

2. **Review the concern**
   (People/HR team) assesses the complaint and evidence to establish whether there appears to be a potential breach of the Code of Conduct or another relevant policy.

3. **Identify the appropriate route**
   Where the complaint does not, on its face, appear to identify a breach of the Code of Conduct or relevant policy, the employee will be informed and **(People/HR team)** will discuss alternative options for addressing the concern.

4. **Proceed fairly**
   Where the complaint is appropriate for this process, it will be managed under the informal or formal stages below, according to the circumstances.

> **Confidentiality:** Information will be shared only with those who need it to manage the concern fairly, subject to legal and procedural requirements.

RESOLUTION FIRST

Informal grievance procedure

Employees are encouraged, where appropriate, to discuss a grievance informally with their manager in the first instance. If the grievance relates to the manager, or it is not appropriate to approach them directly, the employee may raise it informally with their skip-level manager or another appropriate senior manager.

The manager may meet with the employee to discuss the grievance, investigate the matter informally, and issue an outcome or suggest a resolution. If a grievance relates to another employee, the employee is encouraged, where appropriate, to discuss the concern with that person first. A manager may facilitate a conversation to help those involved discuss the issues and seek a resolution.

CONFLICT RESOLUTION & MEDIATION

Before a formal procedure begins, and where appropriate, **(company)** may offer a conflict-resolution session or mediation. The purpose is to help resolve the grievance constructively.

> **Mediation** is an informal, voluntary process in which an independent person, not involved in the complaint, helps those involved resolve their differences. Both parties must be willing to take part and agree to the appointment of a mediator. Further information can be obtained from **(People/HR contact)**.

If a material concern remains unresolved after the informal process, or if informal resolution is not appropriate, the employee should follow the formal grievance procedure.

“Informal resolution is encouraged, but it is not a barrier to raising a formal concern.”

FORMAL PROCEDURE

Stage 1 — raising & hearing a grievance

If an employee wishes to raise a formal grievance, they should submit it in writing to **(People/HR contact or designated submission channel)**, setting out the grievance and reasons in full. The employee will be contacted by **(People/HR team)** and invited to a meeting as soon as reasonably practicable.

THE STAGE 1 MEETING

At the meeting, the employee has the opportunity to explain the grievance and should attend prepared to do so. They may be asked to provide further details and answer questions. At the end of the meeting, they will be advised of relevant next steps.

Who may conduct it?

The meeting may be conducted by the employee's manager or another manager or individual contributor of appropriate seniority, appointed by **(People/HR team)**.

What may follow?

It may be necessary to speak to other employees or witnesses, or carry out further investigation. A further meeting may be arranged if clarification is needed.

RIGHT TO BE ACCOMPANIED

The employee has the right to be accompanied at each stage of the formal grievance procedure by a work colleague or trade-union official. If a companion will attend, the employee should inform **(People/HR team)** in advance and provide their name.

FORMAL PROCEDURE

Stage 1 — attendance, outcome & timing

ATTENDANCE

Employees must take all reasonable steps to attend meetings. If the employee, or their chosen companion, cannot attend for a legitimate reason, the meeting will usually be postponed and reconvened at a later date. In some circumstances, it may be necessary to deal with the grievance in the employee's absence if a mutually convenient time cannot be agreed.

WRITTEN OUTCOME

The employee will be advised in writing of the grievance outcome. Every effort will be made to carry out and complete the procedure within a reasonable timeframe. The outcome letter will remind the employee of their right to appeal and how to exercise it.

> **Outcome quality check:** The written outcome should state the issues considered, the process followed, the decision reached, any actions to be taken, and the right of appeal.

FAIR PROCESS PRINCIPLES

- Give the employee a reasonable opportunity to explain their concern.
- Consider relevant evidence fairly and objectively.
- Use an appropriately senior and impartial decision-maker.
- Keep appropriate records, subject to data-protection requirements.
- Communicate progress and unavoidable delays as appropriate.

FORMAL PROCEDURE

Stage 2 — appeal

If an employee wishes to appeal the grievance outcome, they should set out their grounds of appeal in writing and send them to **(People/HR contact)** within **five working days** of receiving the outcome, unless an alternative timescale is specified by **(company)**.

(People/HR team) will arrange for a manager or appropriate individual contributor, not previously involved in the case and at a suitably senior level, to hear the appeal.

SCOPE OF AN APPEAL

The purpose of an appeal hearing is not normally to investigate the grievance again. It is to consider the specific area or areas with which the employee is dissatisfied. Grounds may include:

1. Procedure

A failure to follow procedure that had a material effect on the grievance outcome.

2. Decision

The evidence did not support the conclusion reached by the Stage 1 decision-maker.

3. New evidence

Relevant evidence has genuinely come to light since the grievance outcome was issued.

4. Appeal meeting

The employee can explain their grounds fully; further investigation may take place if appropriate.

Following the appeal meeting and any further action considered appropriate, the employee will be advised in writing of the appeal outcome. Every effort will be made to complete the appeal within a reasonable timeframe. The decision at this stage is final, with no further right of appeal under this procedure.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Safeguards, conduct & support

AUDIO AND MEETING RECORDING

Audio or meeting recording by any party involved is not permitted unless expressly authorised by **(company)**. While **(company)** will consider relevant evidence, illicit or covert recordings will not normally be considered as part of an investigation. **(company)** does not condone covert workplace recordings and may take disciplinary action where appropriate under its disciplinary procedure.

ACTING IN GOOD FAITH

(company) expects employees who raise a grievance or complaint to do so in good faith. Where there is evidence of abuse of the procedure through malicious, vexatious, intentionally exaggerated or knowingly false claims, the disciplinary procedure may be invoked. This may result in disciplinary action, up to and including dismissal.

PROTECTION FROM RETALIATION OR VICTIMISATION

(company) will not tolerate victimisation or retaliation against an employee who has raised a grievance, or anyone involved in a grievance procedure. Allegations of victimisation or retaliation will be investigated promptly and appropriate action will be taken to address misconduct. Employees who believe they have been victimised or retaliated against should contact **(People/HR contact)**.

EMPLOYEE SUPPORT

(Employee Assistance Programme / support service) is available for personal support. Employees can access details through **(insert support link or contact details)**.

IMPLEMENTATION CHECKLIST

Make this policy yours

Before publishing, make the procedure clear, accessible and workable for employees, managers and people teams.

Replace all placeholders

Insert company name, People/HR contacts, reporting routes, support services, links and document-control details.

Align related policies

Check consistency with the Code of Conduct, disciplinary policy, anti-harassment policy, whistleblowing policy, commission policy and data-protection notices.

Confirm local compliance

Obtain appropriate UK and Ireland legal/employee-relations review, including any collective bargaining obligations or local procedural requirements.

Equip managers

Provide managers with guidance on informal resolution, appropriate escalation, confidentiality, documentation and non-retaliation.

NEED HELP?

For questions or help raising a concern under this procedure, contact **(People/HR contact)** via **(email / telephone / internal support channel)**. A member of the team will discuss the issue or query and the possible next steps.

A fair process protects people, trust and the organisation.